

129

Philip

The practical disciple who asked to see the Father and was shown the Son.

Philip came from Bethsaida, the hometown of Peter and Andrew. Jesus found him and said simply, "Follow me." Philip at once went to find his friend Nathanael and told him they had found the one Moses and the prophets wrote about. When Nathanael scoffed, Philip did not argue. He said, "Come and see." John's Gospel shows Philip as a careful, practical man. He counts the cost of bread for a crowd. He passes a request from some Greeks on to Andrew. At the last supper he asks Jesus to show them the Father. Jesus' answer to Philip is one of the clearest claims in Scripture: "he that hath seen me hath seen the Father."

At a glance

Name	Greek <i>Philippos</i> , "lover of horses"
Home	Bethsaida of Galilee (John 1:44; 12:21)
Friend	Nathanael, whom he brought to Jesus (John 1:45)
Among the Twelve	Always fifth in the lists, often paired with Bartholomew (Matthew 10:3; Luke 6:14)
Main passages	John 1:43–46; 6:5–7; 12:20–22; 14:8–11
Not the same as	Philip the evangelist, one of the seven (Acts 6:5; 8:5–40; 21:8)
Later life	Not recorded in Scripture; see Tradition on page 4

"Jesus saith unto him, Have I been so long time with you, and yet hast thou not known me, Philip? he that hath seen me hath seen the Father."

John 14:9, KJV

The life of Philip

Dates are approximate (AD). Jesus' ministry is dated c. AD 27/28–30 in this study. Only John's Gospel tells stories about Philip; the other Gospels and Acts only list him.

- c. AD 27–28

Toward Galilee

●

Called by Jesus

The day after Andrew and Peter meet Jesus, Jesus goes to Galilee, finds Philip, and says to him, "Follow me."
John 1:43–44
- c. AD 27–28

Galilee

●

Brings Nathanael

Philip tells Nathanael they have found Jesus of Nazareth, the one Moses and the prophets wrote of. When Nathanael doubts, Philip says, "Come and see."
John 1:45–46
- c. AD 29

Near the Sea of Galilee

●

Tested by a question

Facing a hungry crowd, Jesus asks Philip where to buy bread. Philip reckons that two hundred pennyworth would not be enough for each to have a little. *John 6:5–7*
- c. AD 30

Jerusalem

●

Approached by Greeks

Some Greeks at the Passover come to Philip with a request: "Sir, we would see Jesus." He tells Andrew, and they tell Jesus. *John 12:20–22*
- c. AD 30

The last supper

●

Asks to see the Father

Philip says, "Lord, shew us the Father, and it sufficeth us." Jesus answers that whoever has seen him has seen the Father. *John 14:8–11*

Group notes

Key activities

John notes that Jesus asked Philip about bread "to prove him: for he himself knew what he would do" (John 6:6). The question was a test of faith, not a request for advice.

-
- 1 **Followed at once.** He answered Jesus' simple call to follow. *John 1:43*
 - 2 **Shared the news.** He told Nathanael that Jesus fulfilled the Law and the Prophets. *John 1:45*
 - 3 **Invited a doubter.** Instead of arguing, he said to Nathanael, "Come and see." *John 1:46*
 - 4 **Was chosen as an apostle.** He is named among the Twelve in every list. *Matthew 10:3; Mark 3:18; Luke 6:14; Acts 1:13*
 - 5 **Counted the cost.** He calculated that even two hundred pennyworth of bread would not feed the crowd. *John 6:5-7*
 - 6 **Passed on a request.** He brought the Greeks' wish to see Jesus through Andrew to Jesus. *John 12:20-22*
 - 7 **Asked an honest question.** He asked to see the Father and heard Jesus say that to see him is to see the Father. *John 14:8-11*
-

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Philip.

Old Testament

Deuteronomy 18:15	The prophet like Moses, perhaps in Philip's mind (John 1:45)
Echo: Exodus 33:18	Moses asks to see God's glory; Philip asks to see the Father

New Testament

John 1:43-46	Called, and brings Nathanael
John 6:5-7; 12:21-22	Tested about bread; brings the Greeks
John 14:8-9	Asks to see the Father
Matthew 10:3; Mark 3:18; Luke 6:14; Acts 1:13	Listed among the Twelve
Tradition	Polycrates (in Eusebius) says he was buried at Hierapolis; perhaps confused with Philip the evangelist (Acts 21:8-9)

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What three words did Philip say to his doubting friend (John 1:46)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think Jesus tested Philip with a question he already knew the answer to (John 6:5-6)?
3. *Apply:* Philip counted what he had instead of trusting what Jesus could do. Where are you doing the math without Jesus?
4. *Apply:* Who in your life has honest doubts about Jesus, and how could you say "Come and see" to them this week?